16 Free Marketing Methods

How I grew a bootstrapped company from zero to profitability, without investors

Hi, I'm Jen 👋! I built Lunch Money, a personal finance management app. I've been running it for seven years now, and it's always been fully bootstrapped and independent.

For the first five years, I was a company of one. That meant no marketing team, no budget, and no one to hand any of this to. But marketing a company doesn't always mean big ad budgets and paying influencers for exposure.

Below is a list of FREE marketing tactics that helped me grow Lunch Money from zero to profitability.

If available, I've included links to LinkedIn posts and/or Instagram reels where I go into a bit more detail.

I hope this helps and best of luck on your journey! 🚀

Get found

1. Show up where your people already gather. It's free to post on LinkedIn, Instagram, TikTok, and Reddit. Don't just broadcast, add something meaningful to the conversation that's already happening. A single Hacker News post drove my first 1,000 signups.

2. Monitor the discourse around your competitors. If they have a subreddit, that's a goldmine for how their users actually feel. Watch for the opening: did they just raise prices, have a data leak, or are people simply fed up? Move in when the moment is right. (LinkedIn, Instagram, TikTok)

3. Write evergreen content that keeps working. A helpful blog post brings people in for years. It ranks on Google, and now AI chatbots pull from and recommend that same content when someone asks what to use. The best pages to start with are "alternative to" and "versus" pages.

4. Get on podcasts and in front of press. Pitch yourself. Cold email the podcasters, newsletter writers, and journalists in your niche. Most people never send that email, which is exactly why the ones who do get rewarded. One good placement borrows an audience someone else spent years building. And you should never have to pay to be on a podcast or be interviewed. If someone asks you to, walk away.

Give them a reason to choose you

5. Position against your competitors' biggest complaints. Find what people hate about the alternatives and do the opposite. My competitors are known for raising prices, so I make sure everyone knows about our price-lock guarantee.

6. Lead with your differentiator, close with your story. The feature gets their attention. You are the reason they choose you. When I posted about Lunch Money early on, I made sure people knew I was a software engineer building something I wish existed. My initial audience was developers who felt inspired and wanted to support that. (LinkedIn, Instagram, TikTok)

7. Perfect your branding and design. Good design stops the scroll and makes people feel something. Our bright yellow and smiling coin make a finance app feel warm and human, when every competitor looks like a corporate spreadsheet. (LinkedIn, Instagram, TikTok)

Be a person, not a company

8. Build in public, and be vulnerable about it. Share the pricing calls, the mistakes, even the numbers. The honesty itself is the marketing. My best-performing blog post in the early days was literally called "The biggest mistakes I made with Lunch Money... so far."

9. Be the face of your company. Founder-led marketing and growth is highly effective in the age of AI. Make sure your company's About page features you instead of a faceless brand. When people understand the story behind something and feel connected to you, they want to see it succeed. See our About page for inspiration!

10. Talk relentlessly to your first customers. Answer every support email yourself early on. Follow up. Make them feel heard. Use their praise as testimonials (with their permission). Personal support turns users into champions.

Build things you own

11. Build and own a community. A Discord or a subreddit are both great options. Community is the one thing AI can't replicate. Wait until you have enough users or you'll be standing in an empty room. It gives you social proof, a casual forum where people talk to you openly, and users who answer each other's questions before they ever reach your support queue.

12. Build an email list and actually nurture it. Social feeds are rented. The algorithm can cut you off tomorrow. An inbox is yours. Capture the people paying attention somewhere no platform can take away, then send a regular newsletter so both your users and the people who were curious but never signed up don't forget you exist. Don't let your worry of spamming them stand in the way!

13. Let your features market themselves. Build in ways for people to personalize and share what they've made, so the product spreads on its own. That can be as simple as letting users publicly share their profile. For us, we have a way for people to share their category lists as a template and

we also have a developer API that enables developers to bring tools and apps on top of Lunch Money.

14. Amplify your users' own stories. Reshare their wins and testimonials. Real user stories sell better than anything you write about yourself. When you're starting out, social proof and word of mouth are the most important referral sources you have. We also have a community newsletter we send wherein we spotlight a user every month!

Borrow other people's audiences

15. Find other builders at your stage and prop each other up. Team up with founders roughly where you are. Share what's working, learn from each other, shout each other out. 'Like' each other's content and comment! When someone discovers one of you, they discover all of you. This is the social graph at play. I've found and met founder friends on Instagram, TikTok, Reddit, X, and LinkedIn. (LinkedIn, Instagram, TikTok)

16. Grow through partnerships you only pay for when they work. Start an affiliate program where partners earn a cut only when they drive a sale. Work with micro-influencers in exchange for free product instead of cash through a platform like SocialCat. Either way, you never gamble money up front the way you do with ads. (LinkedIn, Instagram, TikTok)

The bottom line

None of this is a formula. Your company isn't mine, your audience isn't mine, and some of what worked for me might do absolutely nothing for you. Heck, maybe paid ads is actually the way to go for your business!

And honestly, a lot of it is luck. I don't love saying that, but pretending otherwise would be dishonest. What I do believe is that luck has a much better chance of finding you if you're persistent and hardworking.

I hope this was helpful and I'm rooting for you!

Let's stay connected!

Follow me on Instagram, LinkedIn, TikTok and Substack (coming soon!).